

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Education Administration English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For school administrators, curriculum coordinators, student-services staff, program directors, admissions teams, registrars, and education operations leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

accommodation

An adjustment intended to address a person's access or participation needs.

accreditation

External recognition that an organization meets defined quality, safety, or professional standards.

action plan

A set of steps, responsibilities, and dates for achieving an objective.

admissions criteria

The stated requirements used to assess applications for entry to a program.

appeal

A request for a decision to be reviewed through an established process.

assessment

A structured evaluation of needs, performance, evidence, or conditions.

attendance

A record or measure of presence at a scheduled activity.

budget

An approved or proposed financial plan for a defined period or activity.

capacity

Available people, assets, time, space, or system throughput for a given workload.

confidentiality

Protecting information from disclosure to people who are not authorized to receive it.

curriculum map

A plan showing how learning outcomes, teaching, and assessments connect across a program.

discipline

A process for addressing behavior under an organization's rules; also a field of study.

equity

Fairness in access or treatment; in finance, ownership interest or residual value.

evidence

Information that supports or challenges a claim or conclusion.

FERPA

Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act: a US federal law concerning education records and related rights.

grading policy

The rules for assigning and explaining assessment results.

guardian communication

Information exchanged with a student's parent or authorized guardian.

intervention

An action intended to change a situation or improve an outcome.

learning outcome

A statement of what a learner should be able to demonstrate after instruction.

need to know

A basis for limiting access to information required for an authorized purpose.

observation

Something directly noticed or measured, distinguished from an interpretation.

placement

Assigning a learner to a suitable level or program using relevant evidence.

professional development

Learning activities intended to improve job-related capability.

program review

A structured evaluation of a program's design, results, and opportunities for improvement.

rubric

A set of criteria and performance descriptions used to assess work consistently.

secure handling

Managing information or material through approved measures that protect it from unauthorized use or disclosure.

staffing model

A plan or calculation describing the roles and staffing needed for a service or workload.

standard

An agreed or authoritative level, specification, or rule used as a reference.

student record

Information maintained about a student under applicable education-record rules.

student support

Services and actions that help learners participate and progress.

sustainability

The ability to maintain an activity over time while addressing relevant resource, social, or environmental effects.

workload

The amount and type of work assigned or required over a period.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Repair a misunderstanding

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Give feedback people can use

In [specific situation], I noticed

The effect was What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Enrollment, Admissions, and Placement

A family asks why an applicant was not offered a place. The administrator needs to explain the published process without discussing other applicants.

I can explain the published criteria and the next steps available for this application. Which part of the decision notice would you like me to clarify? I cannot discuss another applicant's record.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

02 | Curriculum Planning and Learning Outcomes

A curriculum plan lists topics but no observable learning outcomes. Teachers disagree about what an assessment should measure.

A topic says what we cover; an outcome says what learners should be able to do. Let's define those performances first, then check whether the assessment gives learners a chance to demonstrate them.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

03 | Student Support and Intervention

A support meeting has attendance information but no record of which interventions have already been tried.

Could you bring the relevant attendance pattern and the support actions already attempted? We can use those records to plan the discussion and avoid repeating an approach without reviewing its effect.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

04 | Parent and Guardian Communication

A guardian says an email sounded accusatory. The school intended to request a meeting about repeated late arrivals.

I'm sorry the wording sounded accusatory. The purpose is to understand the late arrivals and discuss support. Could we arrange a time to review the pattern and hear your perspective?

Try it again: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

05 | Faculty Coordination and Evaluation

Two teachers use different interpretations of the same grading rubric. Students receive inconsistent explanations.

Let's compare the descriptors against the same sample of work. Where do our interpretations differ? We can agree on clearer explanations and examples before using the rubric again.

Try it again: The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

06 | Compliance, Records, and Privacy

A colleague asks for an entire student file for a narrow administrative task. The authorized scope is unclear.

Could you identify the purpose and the specific records needed? Let's confirm the permitted access and sharing process before providing information from the file.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

07 | Accreditation and Program Review

A program review action plan lists five actions. Three are complete, one is underway, and one has no assigned owner.

Three actions are complete and one is underway. The fifth needs an owner and a target date. I'll make that outstanding decision visible in the program review update.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

08 | Budget, Staffing, and Institutional Priorities

A department can open another class by reallocating staff or hiring temporary support. Each option affects workload differently.

Reallocation uses existing staff but changes their workload; temporary support adds cost and preparation needs. Let's compare the implications for learners and staff before choosing an option.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

US Department of Education: FERPA

<https://studentprivacy.ed.gov/ferpa>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.